COMPARATIVE LITERATURE · LITERARY SEMINAR

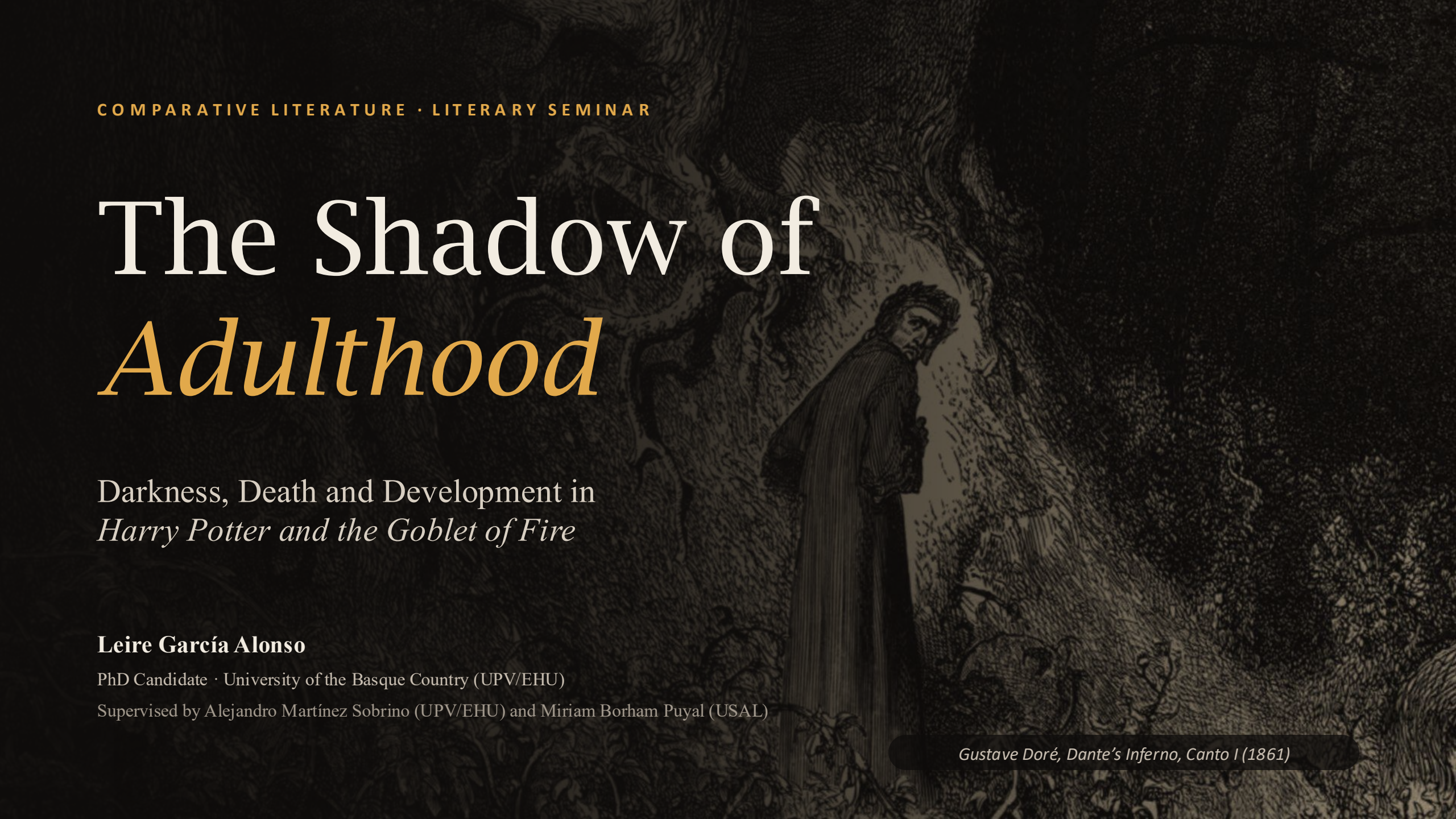
The Shadow of *Adulthood*

Darkness, Death and Development in *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire*

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Gustave Doré, Dante's Inferno, Canto I (1861)

TODAY'S SESSION

Built like a descent:

We discuss, go down into the text together, and climb back up to our conclusions



01 · 0–3 min

Threshold

Who I am, and why why darkness in Harry Potter.



02 · 3–12 min

First look

Your first impressions of the passage. Questions welcome.



03 · 12–30 min

The descent

My reading of chapter 32, one quote at a time.



04 · 30–40 min

The return

Final questions and opinions regarding the passage.



05 · 40–50 min

Open floor

Further passages, then the floor is yours.

THE QUESTION BEHIND my THESIS

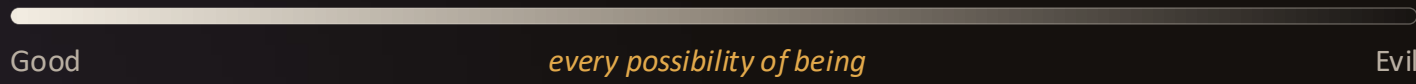
Darkness as a catalyst

Does the saga grow darker as it advances, and what does that darkening mean?

Darkness is more than evil: it is the catalyst that carries Harry from childhood innocence into the complexity of adulthood.

Corpus: **I** *Philosopher's Stone*, innocence · **IV** *Goblet of Fire*, rupture · **VII** *Deathly Hallows*, agency

A child's world has two poles. An adult's has a continuum.



SIX REGISTERS OF DARKNESS

01	02	03	04	05	06
Domestic & ancestral	Institutional & pedagogical	Interpersonal & affective	Moral & ideological	Thanatological & traumatic	Existential & shadow-self

What does darkness do in this passage?



THE PASSAGE

Goblet of Fire, chapter 32

"Flesh, Blood and Bone"

2. OPEN DISCUSSION

01 What caught your attention?

02 Which words made you *feel* the darkness?

03 Where does it live: setting, character or language?

1. PICK ONE, OR SEVERAL

No wrong answers

01 Creates fear

02 Hides information

03 Reflects a character's emotions

04 Marks a transition

05 Makes the familiar strange

06 Suggests moral uncertainty

07 Protects someone or something

08 Something else entirely…

MOMENT A · THE LANDING

A Landing | **B** Death | **C** Grave | **D** Ritual | **E** Rebirth

They were standing instead in a dark and overgrown graveyard; the black outline of a small church was visible beyond a large yew tree to their right. A hill rose above them to their left. Harry could just make out the outline of a fine old house on the hillside.

My reading:

- Darkness does more than set the mood.
- The graveyard functions as an underworld-like threshold.
- Darkness marks a change of world.

TELL ME

- Could the graveyard be read as a distorted version of Hogwarts?
  - What do both spaces teach Harry, and do their methods differ?
- If the graveyard marks a threshold, what exactly lies on each side of it? Is Harry leaving childhood behind, or is he losing a particular illusion about safety?



MOMENT A · THE FIGURE

A Landing | **B** Death | **C** Grave | **D** Ritual | **E** Rebirth

Squinting tensely through the darkness, they watched the figure drawing nearer, walking steadily towards them between the graves. […] he could tell it was carrying something. […] he saw that the thing in the person's arms looked like a baby … or was it merely a bundle of robes?

My reading:

- Darkness permits partial sight.
- Forced to confront something he cannot interpret.

TELL ME

- Why do you think Rowling makes the bundle look like a baby before revealing what it is?
  - What expectations does that image create, and how does the graveyard transform those expectations?
- Why do you think the scene makes us fear this form of Voldemort?
- Would the scene be less frightening if Harry could see the bundle clearly from the beginning?

MOMENT B · THE DEATH

A Landing | **B Death** | C Grave | D Ritual | E Rebirth

Harry's scar exploded with pain. […] he was on the ground and he could see nothing at all, his head was about to split open. […] A blast of green light blazed through Harry's eyelids, and he heard something heavy fall to the ground beside him […] terrified of what he was about to see, he opened his stinging eyes. Cedric was lying spread-eagled on the ground beside him. He was dead.

My reading:

- Darkness prevents Harry from being an active hero.
- Innocence and competence do not necessarily protect you.
- The space of the dead claims someone who had arrived alive.

TELL ME

- Is the green flash a moment of illumination — or does it make the surrounding darkness feel even more powerful?
- Why might Rowling make Harry survive while Cedric dies?
    - What does this survival demand from Harry afterwards?
- Does Harry's inability to see make him less responsible for what happens, or does being forced to witness it create a different kind of responsibility?



MOMENT C · THE GRAVE

A Landing | B Death | **C Grave** | D Ritual | E Rebirth

Before Harry's mind had accepted what he was seeing, […] he felt himself being pulled to his feet. […] was dragging Harry towards the marble headstone. Harry saw the name upon it flickering in the wand-light before he was forced around and slammed against it. The cloaked man was now conjuring tight cords around Harry, tying him from neck to ankles to the headstone. […] Wormtail drew a length of some black material from the inside of his cloak and stuffed it roughly into Harry's mouth.

My reading:

- Harry has no control over his descent.
- Harry gains knowledge, but the knowledge is traumatic.

OVER TO YOU

- Is knowledge empowering in this scene?
  - What kind of knowledge does Harry gain, and what does it cost him?
- If Harry's "descent" is involuntary, can we still call it a journey?
  - What is lost when the protagonist has no choice?



MOMENT D · THE BODY

The bundle of robes that Harry had thought was a baby was close by, [...] stirring fretfully. The thing Wormtail had been carrying had the shape of a crouched human child, except that Harry had never seen anything less like a child. It was hairless and scaly-looking, a dark, raw, reddish black. Its arms and legs were thin and feeble, and its face—no child alive ever had a face like that—was flat and snake-like, with gleaming red eyes. The thing seemed almost helpless.

My reading:

- A body described through images of rawness, darkness and physical distortion.
- The body becomes a visual promise of future danger.

TELL ME

- Why is the image of a baby so disturbing in this scene?
- What happens to our usual associations with childhood — innocence, dependence, potential — in this description?



MOMENT D · THE RITUAL

A Landing | B Death | C Grave | **D Ritual** | E Rebirth

Wormtail lowered the creature into the cauldron; […] Let it drown, *Harry thought, his scar burning almost past endurance, please...* let it drown... *The diamond surface of the water broke and hissed; it sent sparks in all directions, and turned a vivid, poisonous-looking blue. […] Harry couldn't bear to look... but the potion had turned a burning red, the light of it shone through Harry's closed eyelids […] The liquid within turned, instantly, a blinding white.* Let it have drowned*, Harry thought,* let it have gone wrong…

My reading:

- Darkness is a condition of uncertainty.
- Harry cannot necessarily trust what he sees — or what he thinks he sees.

TELL ME

- Why does the scene remain obscure despite all that light?
- Can light ever be as deceptive as darkness?
  - Can you think of another moment in fiction where seeing more does not mean understanding more?
- What is the difference between seeing something and understanding it?
  - And between not knowing something and choosing not to know it?
  - Which of those positions is Harry in?



MOMENT D · THE RITUAL

A Landing | B Death | C Grave | **D Ritual** | E Rebirth

'Bone of the father, unknowingly given, you will renew your son!'

'Flesh — of the servant — willingly given — you will — revive — your master.'

'B-blood of the enemy ... forcibly taken ... you will ... resurrect your foe.'

My reading:

- A disturbing inversion of inheritance.
- The ritual transforms allegiance into bodily sacrifice.
- The boundary between self and other becomes unstable.

TELL ME

- What is the effect of using the father's bone rather than something symbolically associated with him?
- Does Wormtail's willingness make his sacrifice less disturbing, or does it make the scene more disturbing? Why?
- Why does the ritual need the blood of an enemy rather than the blood of a friend or follower?



MOMENT E · THE REBIRTH

A Landing | B Death | C Grave | D Ritual | **E Rebirth**

Through the mist in front of him, he saw, with an icy surge of terror, the dark outline of a man, tall and skeletally thin, rising slowly from inside the cauldron. […] The thin man stepped out of the cauldron, staring at Harry .. and Harry stared back into the face that had haunted his nightmares for three years. Whiter than a skull, with wide, livid scarlet eyes, and a nose that was as flat as a snake's, with slits for nostrils... Lord Voldemort had risen again.

My reading:

- The figure seems to emerge from darkness itself.
- The scene turns death into a source of renewed power and return.
- Harry faces the undeniable truth of his foe's return.

TELL ME

- In what ways is Voldemort's 'rebirth' the opposite of ordinary growth or development?
- How does the ritual change the way we understand the idea of rebirth?
- What makes Voldemort's rebirth feel unnatural rather than hopeful or celebratory?
- Has Harry become more mature — or merely more traumatised? Can those two things be separated?

What has changed?

1. Do you keep your first interpretation?
2. What changed after the theory?
3. Would you add a new reading?
4. Does anything in the text resist your first interpretation?
5. Which opinion would you now defend more confidently?

FINAL THOUGHTS

Did the theories change your reading, or give you words for what you had already noticed?

Did any lens show you something you you had overlooked?

TO TAKE WITH YOU

Further passages

Same lenses, same questions: what turns strange, what does does Harry learn, where is the threshold?

Novel	Ch.	Scene	Lenses
I · Philosopher's Stone	15	Detention in the Forbidden Forest	Gothic · Katabasis
I · Philosopher's Stone	16–17	Through the trapdoor, down to the Mirror	Katabasis · Bildungsroman
II · Chamber of Secrets	16–17	The Chamber beneath the school	Katabasis · Gothic
III · Prisoner of Azkaban	20	The Dementors by the lake	Gothic · Bildungsroman
IV · Goblet of Fire	34	Shades of the dead, the return	Katabasis
V · Order of the Phoenix	6	Grimmauld Place, house of the Blacks	Gothic · Bildungsroman
V · Order of the Phoenix	34–35	The Department of Mysteries, the veil	Katabasis · Bildungsroman
VI · Half-Blood Prince	26	The cave and the lake of the dead	Katabasis · Gothic
VII · Deathly Hallows	16–17	Godric's Hollow on a winter night	Gothic · Bildungsroman
VII · Deathly Hallows	33	Snape's memories in the Pensieve	Bildungsroman
VII · Deathly Hallows	34–35	Into the Forest; King's Cross	Katabasis · Bildungsroman

YOUR TURN

Open *floor*

MY WEBSITE

Questions, objections, other readings: the passage, my project, or anything in between.

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